

Considerations and Procedures for Altering Inaccessible RaCA Site Locations

Rapid Carbon Assessment Project

October, 2010

This procedure and form is only necessary when a site is moved to a different map unit delineation and/or more than 250m from the original site location.

Declaring a site inaccessible:

A site is considered inaccessible when a team cannot reach the site, sample the pedons, and return within a 1 day work period. It is assumed that all reasonable attempts at available transport (ATV etc.) will be made before a site is considered inaccessible. An inaccessible site can be dealt with in two ways: reject the site and choose another (preferred) or alter the site location. This procedure does not apply to sites moved less than 250m away from or anywhere within the same map unit delineation as the original site location.

Office Procedures:

Replacing a single inaccessible site (preferred):

Replace the rejected site with another RaCA site with the same soil group and land use from the supplied list. This process treats an inaccessible site the same as any other rejected site. If there are no sites remaining, contact Skye Wills (skye.wills@lin.usda.gov) or another RaCA team leader to request additional sites.

Remotely altering site locations:

This procedure is only valid when all or nearly all of the sites in a given soil group – land use combination are inaccessible. For example, a group of Histosols in tidal marshes that is only accessible by prohibitively expensive fan boats.

In this case, the MO RaCA coordinator should work with local soil scientists and the RaCA team leaders to identify the characteristics of each site and select an accessible site with the best possible match of those characteristics. This should be done in the field office to avoid biased site selection.

For each site location altered, a 'Site Location Alteration Documentation' form must be filled out and forwarded to the RaCA team leader.

Field Procedure:

Locally (near the site) altering site locations:

This procedure is only valid when a planned sampling expedition encounters unexpected access issues at a remote site. For example, a forest access road is impassable due to debris or other road conditions or for any other reason not foreseen in the remote assessment of the site that the field data collection personnel deem to require substantially more time than planned.

In this case, assess the characteristics of the site to the best of your ability and identify an accessible area with similar characteristics. Choose a site that is as close as possible to the original site in location and characteristics; while still being accessible. You can do this by imagining a line running through your current location and the site; then choose an accessible site along that line. Note that while the new site should be as close as possible to the old site, it's possible that the new site could be behind you and farther away from the target site than your current location. For each site location altered, a 'Site Location Alteration Documentation' form must be filled out and forwarded to the MO RaCA coordinator and then to the RaCA team leader.

REMINDER: Similar soils and other soils in the same group are appropriate substitutes for the target soil.

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Site Location Alteration

RaCA SiteID: _____

Documentation

Provided by:

Altered: remotely or locally

Reason for moving location:

Original Site Location Characteristics (use best information available)

Soil group:

Elevation:

Soil Series:

Slope:

Land use:

Aspect:

Expected plant community:

Other important features:

Altered Site Location Characteristics

Soil group:

Elevation:

Soil Series:

Slope:

Land use:

Aspect:

Expected plant community:

Other important features:

Notes:

Approved by:

Date: